

one year, that has gone up to 24 trillion signals.

We have already announced that we will invest over \$20 billion over the next five years [globally] to advance our security solutions. I mentioned the scale of the business a little while ago... It's more than \$15 billion annually—just the revenue that we have on our security business globally.

Q: You spoke about security, data, metaverse... what kind of investments are you making in India right now?

A: We were amongst the first—if not the first—global public cloud providers to set up a data centre in India, in 2015... We soon had three data centres in the country. That experience of 2015 to 2020 geared us up to serve the country when the pandemic came out of the blue. And literally, in the first six months of the pandemic, we doubled the data centre capacity in the country.

We also announced our Availability Zones in the Central India data centre region in 2021, which creates a higher level of resilience—if one data centre goes down, you can quickly migrate traffic to [another data centre and] continue the work as required.

The other piece of work that we have done is a few years ago, we announced our partnership with Jio and building the Azure data centre footprint uniquely for them. It is a very unique global partnership, where they've [Jio] taken a very long-term view of what they will build for the country, and then how Microsoft will provide its technology and the Azure capability to build a public cloud. And those data centres are now fully built and are being used. [Also,] we announced a few months ago that we will build our biggest data centre in India in Hyderabad—an absolutely new region.

All in all, the Microsoft data centre network in the country is amongst the largest and most scaled of all the public cloud networks that you will see in India. We always invest ahead of the curve.

Data centres are the factories of today. They're not just buildings where you're storing machines because at the end of

ON THE FUTURE OF WORK

Seventy-four per cent of people in India yearn for remote work options, while 73 per cent want more in-person time with their teams. [This means] at least half are at an intersection as they want both. That basically means technology is going to take on a central role in the future of work.

ON THE INDIA STORY

We are on track to complete our fourth best-year-ever in succession... It's not just in terms of financial metrics... but truly making an impact on the landscape of companies that we work with... there's a huge opportunity for India to become a big play for Microsoft globally from a business point of view.

ON INVESTMENTS

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the day, they create a resultant economy around them. And there's a lot of value that gets created. IDC estimated that if you just look at the Microsoft data centre capacity in the country, it may be creating economic value of more than \$9 billion in the entire network. And that is just the tech-related kind of work.

To me, that's the kind of investment we will continue to make and we are thinking about how the whole public cloud platforms will get used for education, for healthcare, for governance, for agriculture, for skilling—all very core sectors in India—and therefore we are kind of driving the investments in a look-ahead fashion.

Q: Microsoft works very closely with start-ups. Among them, there is the tech start-up story that is currently building out. How do you see this progress and what are the sectors in which you think technology will play a greater role as far as start-ups are concerned?

A: I was [recently] at a seminar where we spoke about entrepreneurship, innovation, and technology. And one of the panellists used this example, that they're building a massive supply chain in the country, which is a hard asset. Then I [asked], 'What's the role of technology in this?' He basically said, 'Technology is enabling me to create everything as a capability'. I loved the simplicity of that term... [While building the supply chain, they were] able to take hard assets, big problems, solve them, and marry them so deeply with technology that not just them, but many others will use the service. So, the ability to marry the brick-and-mortar economy with a services economy is a very powerful GDP multiplier as we go forward, and that logistics network is not just going to help that particular unicorn; it's going to help many companies.

At the end of the day, it's all about how much data you can harness and create better models [with the data]. **BT**

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This interview took place before Microsoft announced its results for fiscal 2022